



What does it take to Complete an NHL 0-3 Comeback?

A comprehensive data analysis of every team in NHL history to complete an 0-3 playoff comeback. This project examines what separated them from the teams that couldn't

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Only 4 teams have completed a playoff comeback after getting into a 0-3 deficit:

Toronto Maple Leafs (1942)
Stanley Cup Final



Philadelphia Flyers (2010)
Eastern Conference Semifinals



New York Islanders (1975)
Quarterfinals

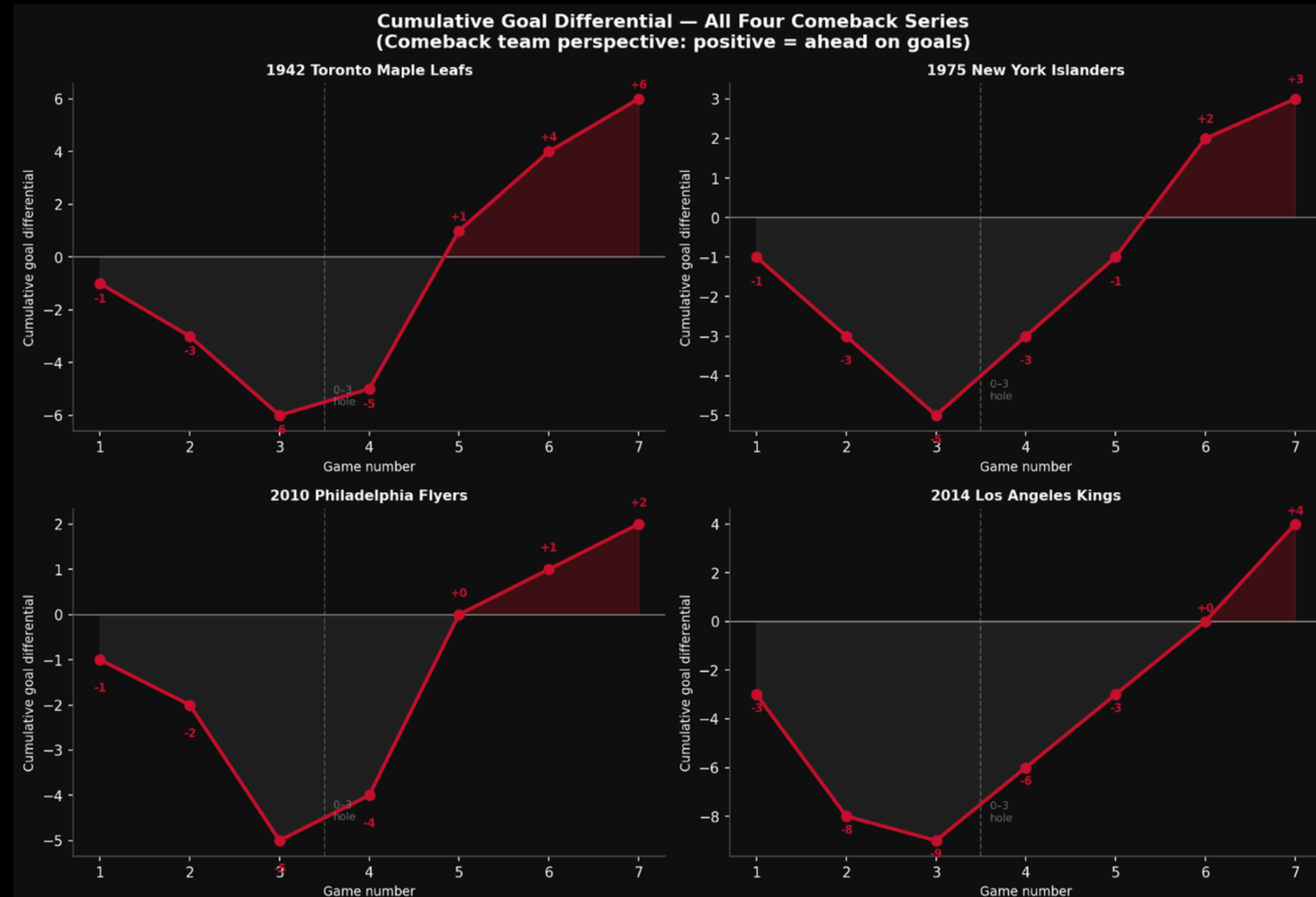


Los Angeles Kings (2014) Western
Conference First Round

This project looks to analyze what separated these teams from the teams that couldn't complete these comebacks looking at: game momentum, goaltending, regular-season quality, special teams, and opponent strength. These teams were compared against 3 baseline teams that went down 0-3 and lost: 2013 Detroit vs. Chicago, 2014 Minnesota vs. Colorado, 2019 Carolina vs. Washington

The Hole

Shows how far negative each team went through game 3, then the full reversal. Gives a visual picture of how deep the hole was the team needed to climb out of in order to begin winning starting Game 4



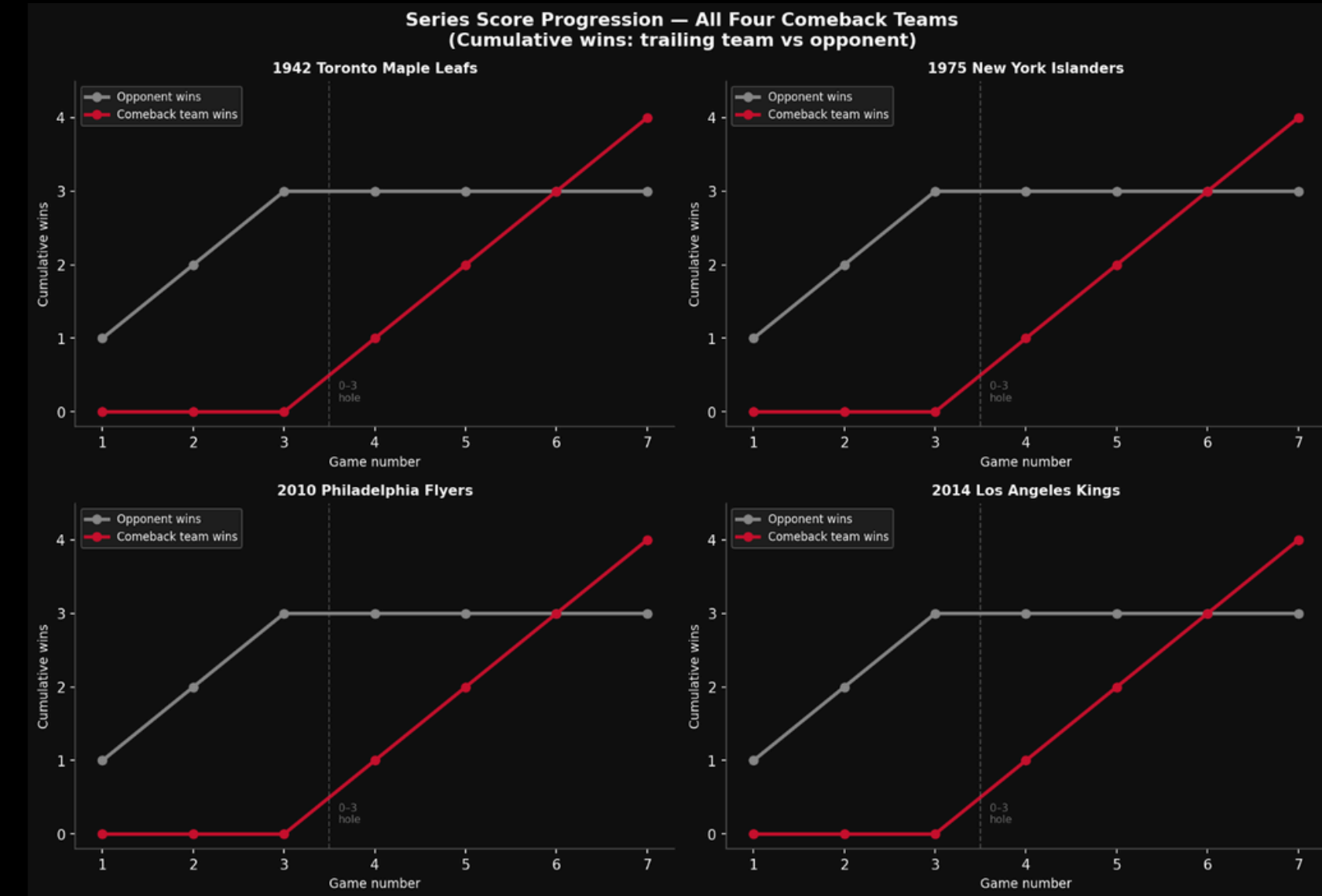
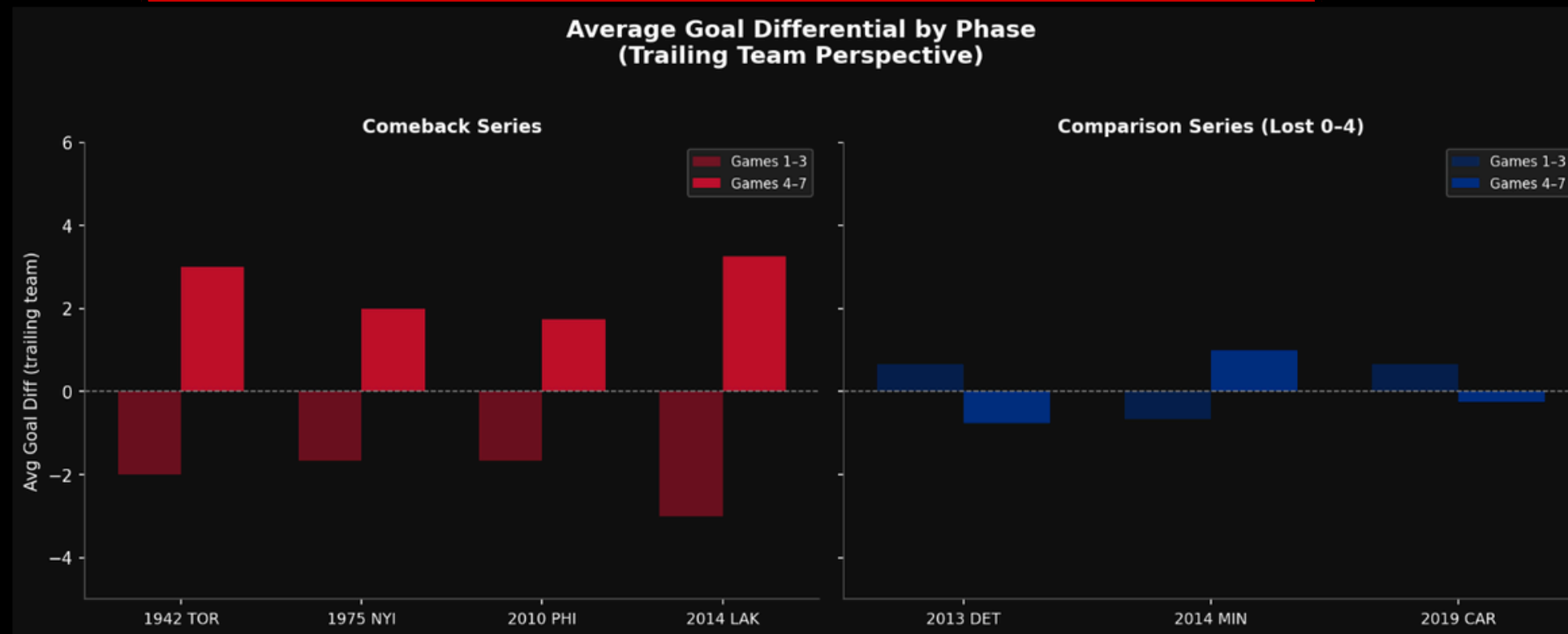
Comeback Teams

Each comeback team had to overcome an extreme cumulative goal differential in order to begin to produce wins starting in Game 4. This the peak of the negative goal differentials happens in Game 3

This chart helps to visualize just how difficult it is to pull off these types of comebacks. So what qualities do these teams have in order to begin to win in such a dramatic fashion?

The Flip

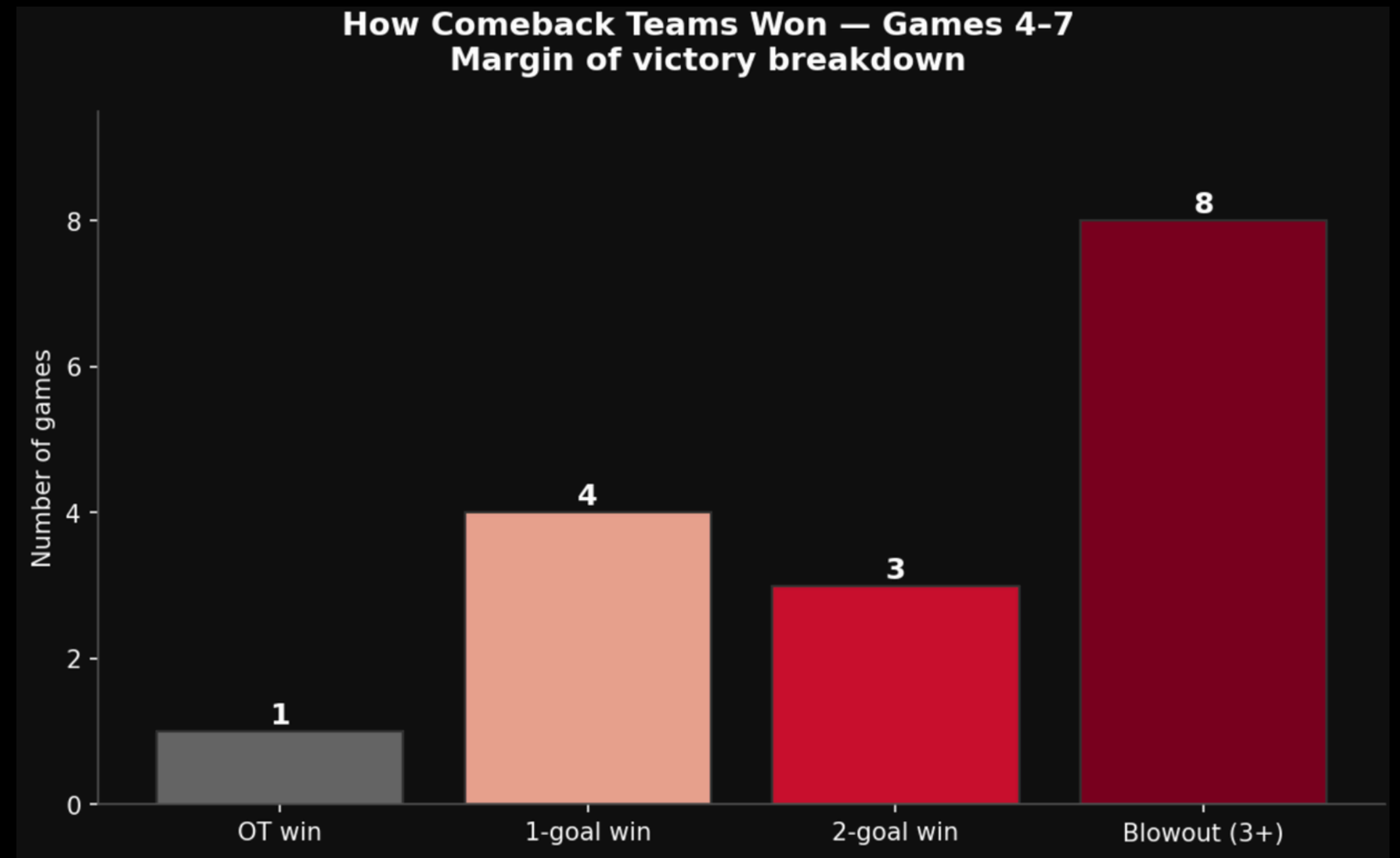
Every comeback series bar flips from negative (games 1-3) to strongly positive (games 4-7), while the comparison series bars stayed mix - no clean flip or dominant back half



This study only looks at teams going 0-3, then 4-0 and these charts help to visualize that stark contrast. The comeback teams didn't just win, they took over completely, with an average +2.50 goal differential in games 4-7

Tracks each comeback, game by game. The opponents come racing out 3-0 in every case and helps to visualize the dramatic flip

Big Winnings



Winning Big

The comeback teams didn't just win, they won big. In the 16 wins across games 4-7, 8 of them were blowouts (3+ goal margins), 3 were 2-goal wins, 4 were 1-goal wins, and only 1 went to OT

Comparison Teams

Looking at the comparison teams' wins in the back half, all were much tighter, with a 1.71 average margin of victory as opposed to the comeback teams 2.50

The 2014 Kings

The Kings were the major showcase of the blowout numbers. They won games 4-7 by 3, 3, 3, and 4 goals

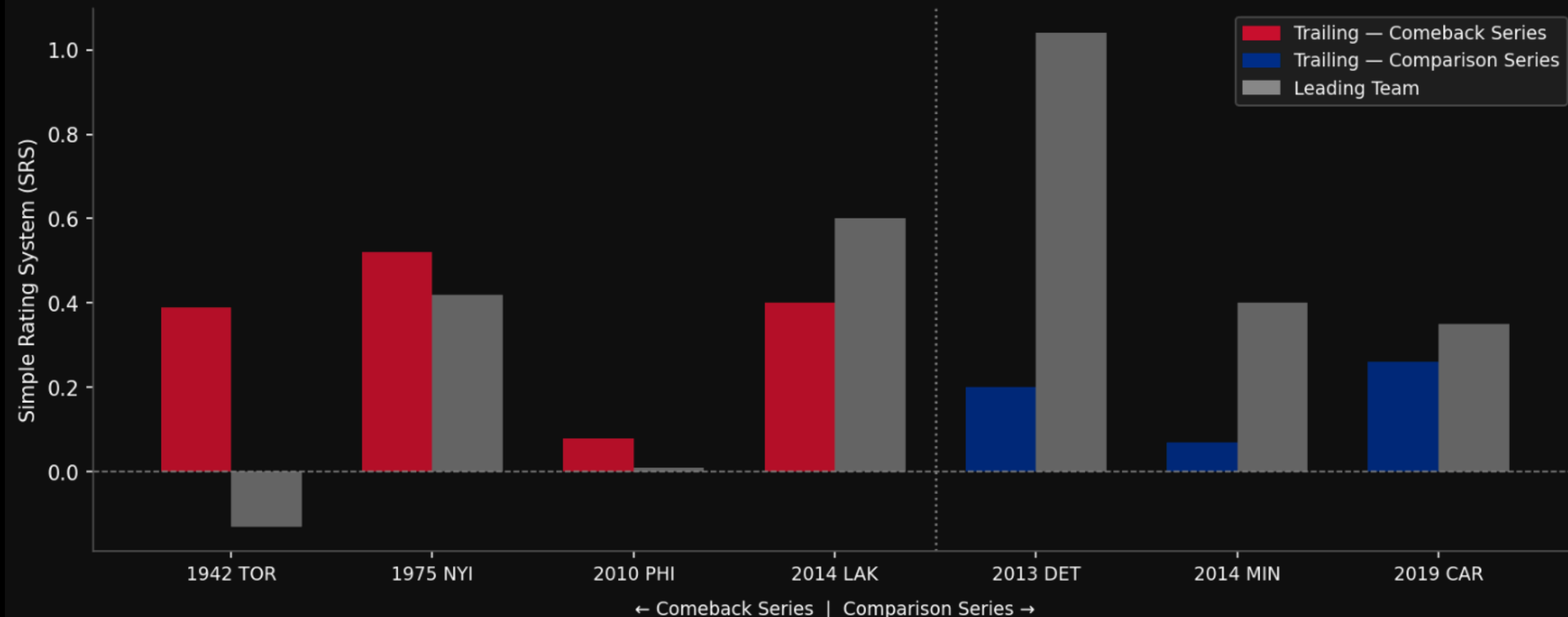
Realistic Comebacks

Every comeback team was playing a beatable team. Toronto, New York, and Philadelphia all had stronger regular season strength than the teams they were competing against in the post-season. The Los Angeles Kings were not as strong, but were also not competing against a dynasty, which made their comeback possible.

Opponent Strength

The major limitation of the ability to complete the 0-3 comeback was the strength of the team they were competing against

Regular-Season Strength (SRS) — Trailing Team vs Leading Team per Series



Dynasty Team

The greatest example of failing to make a comeback against a dynasty team were the 2013 Detroit Redwings against the Chicago Blackhawks. In 2013, Chicago seemed unbeatable, they were an unbelievable dynasty that made the 0-3 comeback nearly impossible for the Redwings, which can be clearly seen in the stark difference between the Regular-Season strength of the two teams

The Reset Event

Head coach Hap Day
benched his best scorer
and veteran defenseman



The Flyers made a goalie change
as well as Simon Gagne's return
from injury - they had two major
momentum swings happening at
once



Made a goalie change,
which is statistically
backed by the numbers
(0.884 → 0.969 SV%)



The Kings are the most
interesting case - they made no
personnel changes at all, which
means it comes down to purely a
system and attitude reset

The Shift in Goalies

New York Islanders - The Textbook Goalie Change

Billy Smith went 0.853, 0.936, and 0.839 across his three losses, averaging 0.876. After Glenn Resch came in, he went 0.964, 0.947, 0.969, and 1.000, averaging 0.970. This gave the NYI a 0.094 SV% improvement

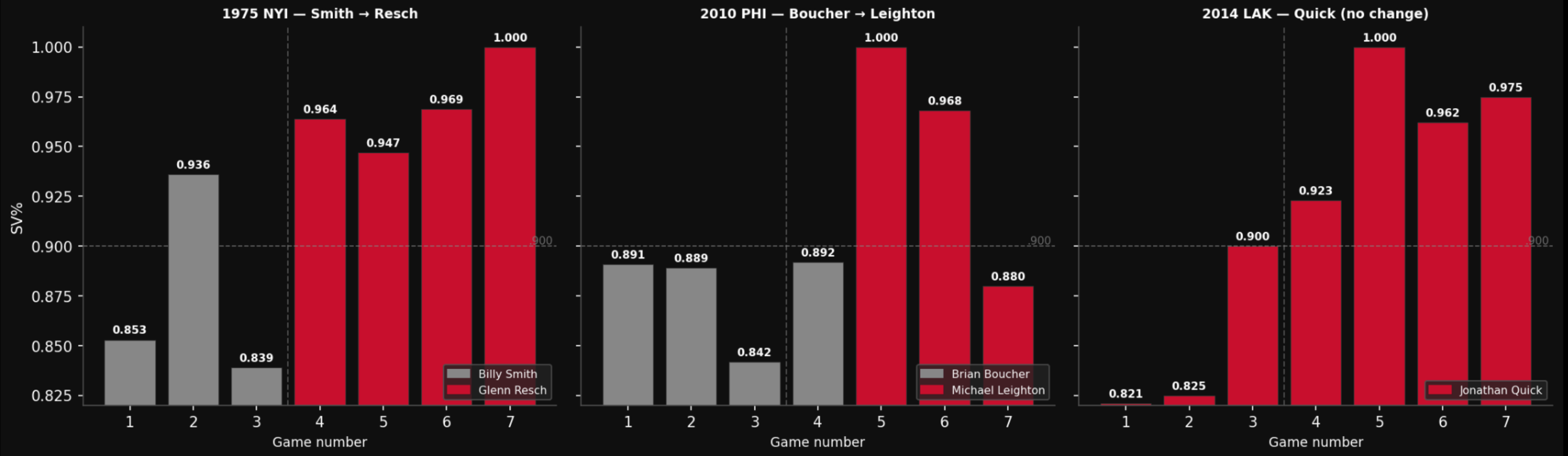
Philadelphia Flyers - A Nuanced Case

Boucher's game-by-game numbers were 0.891, 0.889, and 0.842 - trending downward in his 3 losses (games 1-3), before winning game 4 and then being pulled mid-game 5. Then at the same time, Leighton replaced him and went 1.000 (partial game appearance), 0.968, and 0.880. While on the other side Rask was trending upward in the first 3 games then collapsed as the pressure flipped

Los Angeles Kings - The Remarkable case

Jonathan Quick went 0.821, 0.825, and 0.900 while losing, all poor performances. Then in games 4-7 he went 0.923, 1.000, 0.962, and 0.975. The Kings had no personnel changes or goalie changes, the team, including the goalie, just seemed to decide to play better

Comeback Team Goalie SV% Per Game (grey = original starter, red = replacement)



In most cases, it wasn't just the comeback team whose goalie changed, it was the opposing team's too. The combination of the comeback goalie's improving and the opposing team's goalie declining was a major factor in the 0-3 comeback

The Comeback Formula



A Legitimately Good Team

The comeback team needs to be a legitimately good team, not a team that just barely made its way into the playoffs. The comeback team's Regular-Season strength needed to be good enough to be considered a playoff team

A Beatable Opponent

The comeback team needs to be facing a beatable team. They can not be playing against a dynasty in order for the comeback to remain possible

A Concrete Reset

Before going into Game 4, the comeback team needs some sort of reset, whether it is a personnel change with players returning from injury or a goalie change, or even a mental reset to start the comeback in Game 4